

ROCKY: THE ROCKEFELLER CHRISTMAS TREE
The Little Tree with Big Dreams

An animated family feature

Written by

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Based on her children's book
"ROCKY: The Rockefeller Christmas Tree --
The Little Tree with Big Dreams"

FADE IN:

EXT. SKY OVER THE HIDDEN FOREST - DAY

Snow. The first fat flakes of the season, drifting down toward an ocean of evergreens folded between hills, far from any road, far from everything.

A hush over the whole world. Then, from somewhere below --

CHIPMUNK (O.S.)
Coming through! Coming throuuugh!

EXT. THE HIDDEN FOREST - CONTINUOUS

A CHUBBY CHIPMUNK barrels along a fallen log, cheeks packed to bursting, one more acorn balanced on his head. Behind him squirrels stream in every direction with nuts and seeds and whole pinecones -- a furry supply line in full happy panic.

They pour past two enormous OAKS, bare-branched and frowning. If trees can frown. These two can.

OLD OAK
Snow. Already.

SECOND OAK
You say that every year.

OLD OAK
It comes early every year.

A snowflake settles on the Old Oak's longest branch. He shakes it off with tremendous dignity. Three more land.

In a meadow beyond them, REINDEER run drills over a row of snowdrifts. They leap in formation, graceful and strong --

Except one. A YOUNG REINDEER clips the top of every single drift. Poomf. Poomf. Poomf. He trots to the back of the line with his head held high.

YOUNG REINDEER
I'm pacing myself.

The two reindeer ahead of him trade a look and say nothing.

And now something moves through the forest faster than any squirrel: news. It leaps from branch to branch, burrow to burrow, tree to tree, gathering voices as it goes --

ANIMALS (V.O.)
(overlapping, building)
It's time -- it's time -- they're
choosing -- the choosing -- IT'S
TIME!

The whole forest is buzzing. Because it is time to choose the Rockefeller Christmas Tree.

We drift away from the noise. Down a slope where the trees grow thinner and the light grows stingy. Into a hollow the news reaches last.

EXT. ROCKY'S CLEARING - CONTINUOUS

A small clearing. Gray light. Thin soil. One shaft of sun makes it down through a gap in the canopy, and that is all the sun there is.

In the middle of it stands one small NORWAY SPRUCE.

This is ROCKY. His branches are bare in patches and bent in funny directions. His needles, where he has needles, are more brown than green. He is not the biggest tree in the forest, and he is not the strongest. He is quite the opposite.

At this particular moment, he is concentrating with everything he has.

ROCKY
Straight... straight...

He hauls himself upright -- taller -- taller -- his crooked top wobbling toward the sky --

-- and slumps back into his usual comfortable lean, out of breath.

The buzzing rolls down the slope and finally reaches him. His branches lift, every bent one of them.

ROCKY (CONT'D)
It's time!

EXT. THE OAKS' RISE - DAY

The heart of the forest, and the closest thing it has to a town square: a rise of stone and snow beneath the two great Oaks. Every animal in the forest is packed onto it -- chipmunks on stumps, rabbits on rocks, birds three-deep on every branch that will hold them.

Threading through the crowd, holding a small silver hand MIRROR out in front of her like a lantern, comes MRS. PICKLES the skunk. She is not watching where she is going. She does not need to. The crowd makes room for her tail.

She settles onto the best rock, checks her reflection, and begins to comb her hair.

Above the crowd, on the lowest branch of the Old Oak, lounges AJ the squirrel -- small, quick-eyed, tail flicking. He surveys the crowd like it assembled just for him.

The Old Oak clears his throat. It sounds like a door that has needed oiling for a hundred years. The forest hushes.

OLD OAK

Every winter, the same fuss. Every winter, the same speech. I don't know why it always has to be me that gives it.

SECOND OAK

Because you love it.

OLD OAK

I do not love it.
(settling his branches;
loving it)
The judges are coming. Before the moon is full, they will fly over this forest looking for one tree. The grandest tree. THE tree.
(beat)
Who stands for the choosing?

Silence. The good kind. The kind before fireworks.

Then, from the ridge -- a voice like a church organ.

WHITE PINE (O.S.)

The White Pine stands!

The crowd turns as one. Far up the ridge, the MIGHTY WHITE PINE draws himself to his full, staggering height, wearing the snow like a king's coat. Gasps. Applause. Somewhere a chipmunk faints.

More voices now, ringing out across the forest, one great tree after another, each grander than the last --

FIR (O.S.)

The Douglas Fir stands!

BLUE SPRUCE (O.S.)
The Blue Spruce stands!

With each call the crowd whirls to find the tree rising proud
in the distance. It is like watching mountains volunteer.

The Old Oak nods along, checking names off some invisible
list.

OLD OAK
And Bruce Spruce?

A BLUE JAY drops out of the sky onto the Oak's branch,
breathless, self-important.

BLUE JAY
Bruce Spruce says the judges know
where to find him.

Murmurs through the crowd -- impressed murmurs. Of course he
did. That is exactly the sort of thing Bruce Spruce would
say.

OLD OAK
(dry)
Naturally.
(to the forest)
Does any other tree stand for the
choosing?

A pause. The Oak draws breath to close the ceremony --

ROCKY (O.S.)
(very small, very far
away)
I do.

The Old Oak stops. The crowd goes still. Everyone heard it.
Nobody can find it.

OLD OAK
...Who said that?

ROCKY (O.S.)
(with everything he has)
I DO! Rocky! From the hollow!

Beat.

Then the entire crowd is moving -- squirrels, rabbits, birds,
the chipmunk who fainted, all of them streaming down the
slope in a rustling flood, funneling into --

EXT. ROCKY'S CLEARING - CONTINUOUS

-- the little gray hollow, where Rocky stands as tall as he can get, which is not very, his crooked top wobbling with the effort.

The crowd stares at him.

He smiles back at all of them.

ROCKY

I stand for the choosing.

One beat of perfect silence.

Then the laughter comes. Not cruel from any one mouth -- just everywhere at once, rolling around the hollow, and all of it landing on the one small tree in the middle.

AJ is delighted. This is the best thing that has happened all winter. He springs from the crowd, hits the snow, and circles Rocky with a showman's strut, singing it --

AJ

You're limp and bare! You'll never
be the Rockefeller Christmas
Treeee!

Big laugh. AJ takes a bow. Takes another.

Mrs. Pickles has arrived at the front of the crowd without ever lowering her mirror. Now she looks at Rocky over the top of it -- one long, unhurried look, the way you look at a stain on good furniture.

MRS. PICKLES

What makes you think you can be the
grandest tree for all the world to
see?

She does not wait for an answer. She was never waiting for an answer. She turns, and her tail sweeps past Rocky's trunk, and the crowd follows her out of the hollow, still chuckling, the show over.

AJ goes last, walking backward so Rocky can hear the reprise.

AJ

(sing-song, fading)
Limp and baaare...

And then the hollow is empty again, and quiet, the way it is always quiet.

Rocky stands there in the gray light. Slowly, his branches lift -- and his top lowers, all the way down.

Tears trickle down his twisted branches, one branch to the next, the long way, because on Rocky even tears cannot travel straight.

EXT. THE OAKS' RISE - DUSK

The snow has picked up. The crowd has thinned to the young ones -- SAPLINGS at the edge of the rise, fuzzy young squirrels, a rabbit already half asleep -- gathered below the Old Oak the way children gather anywhere a story is about to happen.

YOUNG SAPLING

Tell about the trees who went before!

OLD OAK

I told it last year.

YOUNG SAPLING

Tell it again!

OLD OAK

Nobody listened last year either.

SECOND OAK

Tell the story, you old stump.

The Old Oak grumbles. Creaks. Settles.

And when he speaks again his voice has changed -- slower, warmer, worn smooth like a stone the river likes.

OLD OAK

Every winter, since before your grandmothers were acorns... they choose one tree.

As he speaks, the falling snow between his branches begins to catch the last light -- and the story comes alive in it, soft-edged and glowing, like an old picture book opening:

THE STORYBOOK -- A tree, grand and green, rising from a forest of bowed and waving branches.

OLD OAK (V.O.)

The chosen tree is carried out of the forest -- the only tree that ever leaves.

(MORE)

OLD OAK (V.O.) (CONT'D)
It goes on a long journey, to the
greatest city in all the world.

The tree, riding, wrapped warm. A city of towers rising
ahead, windows lit like stars stood up on end.

OLD OAK (V.O.)
And there, in the heart of that
city, they raise it up. And dress
it in lights. And on one night --
one night in all the year --

The little glowing tree bursts alight, and a sea of tiny
faces turns up toward it, shining.

OLD OAK (V.O.)
-- the whole world comes to see it.
And the whole world is glad.

YOUNG SAPLING (V.O.)
And after?

The city dissolves into rolling white. Northern lights. And
on a hill of snow at the top of the world: TREES. Rows and
rows of them, every one still dressed in lights, every one
still shining -- a forest of every chosen tree there ever
was.

OLD OAK (V.O.)
After... the North Pole. Where
every chosen tree from every year
gone by still stands. Together. Lit
forever.

BACK TO SCENE

The snow is just snow again. The little ones sit shining-
eyed. The Old Oak looks caught -- cleared his own throat into
feeling something, and annoyed about it.

OLD OAK
Carried out. Carried up. Lit for
all the world to see. And
remembered, evermore --

ROCKY (PRE-LAP)
(a whisper)
-- at the top of the world.

EXT. ROCKY'S CLEARING - SAME TIME

Rocky, alone in his hollow, far from the story circle, mouthing the ending along with the Oak. Word for word. He has it by heart. He has had it by heart for years.

He looks up through his one gap in the canopy at the first stars.

ROCKY

The top of the world.

He says it the way other people say amen.

EXT. ROCKY'S CLEARING - NIGHT

Later. The snow is falling for keeps now -- flakes the size of marshmallows, filling up the sky, filling up the quiet.

Rocky sleeps, or nearly. His branches droop soft under their first white load.

A shadow slides across the whole clearing.

It keeps sliding. There is a great deal of it.

Rocky opens his eyes -- and looks up. And up.

The tallest tree he has ever seen stands over him at the edge of the hollow, snow swirling around it like weather happens to other trees. High in its branches, a familiar small shape lounges: AJ.

The big tree's voice comes down like it is falling from a height.

BRUCE SPRUCE

I heard you're going to enter the
Rockefeller Christmas Tree contest?

ROCKY

(voice trembling)

Uh... yes.

(peering up)

Who are you?

The big tree seems delighted to be asked. He tips his top -- a slow, gracious, terribly pleased-with-itself bow -- and holds out his branches.

BRUCE SPRUCE

The name is Spruce. Bruce Spruce.

He straightens up and lets that sit a moment, as if the name alone usually settles things. Then he leans down close -- close enough that his shadow puts out the stars.

BRUCE SPRUCE (CONT'D)
Between you and me, you don't stand
a chance. You're sure to lose --
not that I have anything to worry
about, judging by the looks of you.

AJ scrambles halfway down Bruce's trunk, puffs up his chest, and does his very best Bruce. It comes out squeaky and squirrely and about nine sizes too small.

AJ
Yeah, Rocky. Withdraw your name.

Rocky is shaking. Every needle of him. He plants what roots he has, and he says it anyway.

ROCKY
You don't scare me!

LITTLE VOICE (O.S.)
Leave Rocky alone, Bruce.

Everyone freezes. The voice came from behind Rocky --

-- and out of the snowfall rises a FAIRY the size of a teacup, wings throwing off light like a struck match. She flies straight up to Bruce Spruce's enormous face, plants herself in the air an inch from his nose, and shakes her finger at him in the most serious way a delicate wood fairy can.

Bruce regards her. There is a great deal more of him than there is of her. Somehow this does not seem to be helping him.

He pulls himself back up to his full height and turns to go, gathering AJ and his dignity on the way.

BRUCE SPRUCE
(over his shoulder)
Remember what I said, Rocky.

And he goes, laughing his big laugh, AJ's smaller laugh riding along on top of it, both of them fading off into the snow until the hollow is quiet again.

The fairy watches them all the way gone. Nods once, job done. Then she turns to Rocky --

-- and everything about her changes, like the sun coming out.

MARY LOUISE
Hello! I'm Mary Louise, the
Guardian of the Forest.

ROCKY
Of... the whole forest?

MARY LOUISE
Every needle.

She buzzes a full circle around him, taking stock, trailing a ribbon of light through the falling snow.

MARY LOUISE (CONT'D)
Bruce and AJ -- they're full of hot
air.

She loops under a bent branch and over the top of him, dancing more than flying, tumbling through the snowflakes -- and comes up in front of his face, hopeful. Nothing. Rocky's top is still low.

So she tries harder. A pirouette. A little bow, mimicking Bruce -- "the name is Spruce" -- puffing her tiny self up like a burly tree.

A sound escapes Rocky. Almost a laugh. Best she's going to get, and she takes it.

ROCKY
(all in a rush, hope
spilling out of him)
Are you an enchanted fairy? Will
you make me handsome and strong,
like Bruce Spruce and the mighty
White Pine?

Mary Louise stops dancing.

She hovers there in the snowfall, small and bright, and looks at this little bent tree asking to be made into a different tree. When she answers, it is the gentlest no in the world.

MARY LOUISE
There is no such thing as magic.
You just have to believe.

ROCKY
...That's it?

MARY LOUISE
(a grin)
That's everything.

And she winks --

MARY LOUISE (CONT'D)
Goodbye for now!

-- and she is gone. Just like that. As quickly as she came. A last scatter of light settles down through the marshmallow snow, and the clearing is empty, and Rocky is alone with the worst gift anyone has ever given him.

ROCKY
(to the empty air)
Believe.

He says the word like it is a rock someone handed him when he asked for bread.

He looks at the place where she was. He looks up at his one gap of sky. The snow comes down and down.

ROCKY (CONT'D)
(trying it out)
Believe...

And somewhere in the saying of it, the word starts to change shape in his mouth. His branches come up a little. His top comes up after them.

ROCKY (CONT'D)
Believe? That's what I'll do! I'll
drink lots of water -- and I'll
grow tall and green!

He plants himself in the middle of his hollow, in the best of his bad light, and shuts his eyes tight.

ROCKY (CONT'D)
I am tall, fluffy, and green.

He opens one eye. Looks down at himself.

He is small, patchy, and brown.

He shuts the eye again.

ROCKY (CONT'D)
I am tall, fluffy, and green.

Nothing. The snow falls. Far away, an owl asks its one question.

ROCKY (CONT'D)
(quieter; meaning it more)
I am tall... fluffy... and green.

And on one bent branch, halfway along, where the needles have always come in brown --

-- one needle stands up straight.

And turns green. Deep, dark, glossy Christmas green. One single needle, bright as a lit match in all that gray.

Rocky opens his eyes. Finds it. Stares at it.

His whole crooked body slowly fills up with light -- not magic light. Just joy, which from a distance looks the same.

ROCKY (CONT'D)
(a whisper, to the needle,
to the snow, to the whole
sleeping forest)
I am tall, fluffy, and green.

Around him the snow keeps falling, fat and soft and patient, and the little voice keeps going in the dark, saying it over and over, like a lantern that has decided not to go out.

FADE OUT.

END OF ACT ONE

ACT TWO

EXT. ROCKY'S CLEARING - DAWN - DAYS LATER

Frost on everything. Rocky, eyes shut, exactly where we left him.

ROCKY
I am tall, fluffy, and green.

Three needles now. He checks. Counts them. Nods like a tree with a lot of work ahead of him, and gets to it.

EXT. THE STREAM - DAY

Rocky leans -- strains -- stretches one root toward a thread of snowmelt trickling past the edge of his hollow. It is about a root's-length too far. He grunts. Reaches. Reaches --

The root finds water. Rocky drinks like it is a contest.

Downstream, the Chubby Chipmunk stops to watch. Watches a while longer. Slowly lowers his acorn.

EXT. ROCKY'S CLEARING - VARIOUS - WINTER DAYS

The growing. Not magic -- work, in pieces:

-- Rocky stretching his crooked top toward his one gap of sun, holding the stretch, trembling, holding it anyway.

-- Morning. Gray. Rocky, plainly not believing a word of it, saying it regardless.

ROCKY

I am tall, fluffy, and green.

-- A snowfall buries him completely. A beat. The snow mound speaks, muffled but unbeaten.

ROCKY (CONT'D)

I am tall, fluffy, and green.

-- The bent branch, no longer bent quite so far. A whole row of green needles now, standing up like the first brave soldiers of an arriving army.

-- Rocky drinking. Rocky stretching. Rocky saying it. Sun and snow and sun and snow --

-- and one bright morning, branches UNFOLD. Not all at once and not neatly -- one after another, shaking off snow, opening out of him the way a hand opens after being a fist for years. Lush. Dark. Green.

EXT. ROCKY'S CLEARING - DAY

Rocky stands in his hollow -- twice his old size, full and deep green, his top nearly straight and reaching through the gap into direct sunlight for the first time in his life.

He looks down at himself. He hardly dares to.

Then he sways -- a big, proud, gleaming sway, snow flying off him like confetti -- and bellows it to the whole ridge:

ROCKY

Look at me!

The echo rolls out through the forest.

ROCKY (CONT'D)

LOOK AT ME!

Birds go up off the ridge. Somewhere, faintly, a chipmunk cheers.

EXT. THE THIN-LIGHT SLOPE - DAY

The scrubby slope below Rocky's hollow, where the light is worse than anywhere. A stand of SAPLINGS grows here, scrawny and patchy and bent -- five little trees that look like Rocky used to look.

They are all staring up the slope at him. The smallest one, PIP, finally gets the nerve.

PIP
How did you do that?

Rocky looks down at them. At the bad light. At the thin soil. He remembers every inch of it.

ROCKY
A fairy told me the secret.

The saplings crowd forward, thrilled. Magic. They knew it.

ROCKY (CONT'D)
There is no such thing as magic.
You just have to believe.

The saplings stare at him.

PIP
...That's it?

ROCKY
(a grin)
That's everything.

They find this deeply disappointing. He teaches them anyway.

EXT. THE THIN-LIGHT SLOPE - DAWN

Rocky, leaning down the slope. Five little trees in a row, eyes shut tight, saying it raggedly, each at their own speed, none of them together:

SAPLINGS
I am tall -- fluffy -- and green --

PIP
(last, loudest, wrong)
-- and FLUFFY!

ROCKY
Close enough.

He stays with them while the sun comes up. Hours he could be growing. Nobody says anything about that, including the movie.

EXT. THE OAKS' RISE - DAY

Mrs. Pickles and AJ, heads together beneath the Old Oak, whispering. Mrs. Pickles has actually lowered her mirror for this, which tells you everything.

MRS. PICKLES

Have you seen Rocky? He's changed.

AJ

His branches reach the sky. It must be magic.

MRS. PICKLES

Yes. The Guardian of the Forest must have cast a spell on him!

AJ

I'd better tell Bruce!

He is gone before the sentence lands, a gray streak over the snow.

EXT. THE FOREST'S EDGE - DAY

The long shadows at the border of the forest. Every tree on the ridge behind is practicing standing tall for the judges -- chests out, snow shaken, tops straight.

All except one.

Bruce Spruce stands in the shadows at the very edge, with a clear view up the slope to a full, green, gleaming Rocky. AJ perches on Bruce's lowest branch. They have been watching a long time.

BRUCE SPRUCE

You may be right, AJ... it's magic.

AJ

You're going to lose now, huh, Bruce?

Bruce's top swivels slowly toward AJ. AJ becomes very interested in a pinecone.

BRUCE SPRUCE
Bah! We must find a way to catch
the fairy and make her change Rocky
back.

AJ
(voice trembling)
How will we do that?

BRUCE SPRUCE
We'll set a trap!

On Bruce's face: the bright, terrible delight of a big idea
arriving in a big head.

EXT. THE FOREST - DAY - MONTAGE

Bruce gathers twigs. This is slow, laborious work for a tree -
- bending, snapping, weaving with branch-tips built for no
such thing. He keeps at it with the furious patience of the
deeply offended.

The net takes shape between his branches: crude, knotted,
absurd. The biggest creature in the forest, building the
smallest cage in the world.

AJ watches, holding one twig, contributing nothing.

EXT. MARY LOUISE'S HOUSE - DAY

Deep in a bramble where nobody looks: a tiny house of pebbles
and dried leaves, snug as anything, smoke no thicker than a
pencil line rising from a chimney the size of a thimble.

Through a round little window we see her at her workbench:
MARY LOUISE, sleeves rolled, making the champion's ornaments.
Globes of frozen dew. A star no bigger than a snowflake, and
finer. Work so delicate she holds her breath to do it.

She holds one ornament up to the light. Not quite. She sets
it back down and starts again.

Outside, above the bramble, two eyes and a gray tail: AJ,
posted on a branch. Watching. Not enjoying it.

Mary Louise flits out her front door, ornament list in hand,
and zips off between the trees.

AJ
(hissed)
Quick, Bruce! Get your net!

The bramble EXPLODES upward -- Bruce, rising out of the snowbank behind it, net swinging in a wide, whistling arc --

Mary Louise turns at the sound. Whoosh.

The net drops over her.

She sits down hard on the snow, tangled in twigs, more startled than hurt.

AJ (CONT'D)
We caught you!

He cheers it. Then hears himself cheer it, and stops.

Bruce looms over the net. All of him. It is like being frowned at by the sky.

BRUCE SPRUCE
You used magic on Rocky! Change him
back -- or when I get back, I'm
knocking down your house!

Mary Louise looks up through the twigs at the enormous creature threatening her tiny home. And she giggles.

MARY LOUISE
Magic? Oh, I didn't do anything
like that!

BRUCE SPRUCE
(to AJ)
Keep her here.

And he goes, hauling himself off toward the ridge and the judging, ground trembling, dignity restored, certain he has fixed everything.

AJ drags the net -- gently, gentler than he means to -- behind a big snow mound, out of sight. Mary Louise watches him do it. He will not meet her eye.

EXT. THE RIDGE - DAY

Judging morning.

The forest has never looked like this. Every tree scrubbed by wind and dressed in fresh snow, standing at attention in long proud rows. The animals line the slopes like a parade crowd. Somewhere a woodpecker drums a drumroll and is shushed.

And in his hollow, at his full height, stands ROCKY.

Green top to bottom. Full. Straight -- or near enough that you'd never dwell on it. The morning light has found the gap in the canopy and laid itself over him like it was sent for.

He is magnificent. He knows it. It is the best feeling of his entire life, and his face can't hold all of it.

Far off, beyond the ridge: a sound. THUD-THUD-THUD-THUD.

Every animal head turns. The judges are coming.

And under the thudding, thin as a thread, from behind a snow mound down the slope --

MARY LOUISE (O.S.)
(very small)
Hello? ...Anyone?

Rocky's branches go still.

He looks toward the ridge -- the helicopters, the crowd, the whole morning his entire life has aimed at.

He looks toward the snow mound. Nobody else so much as glances at it. Nobody else can hear it. He is the only tree close enough.

The THUD-THUD grows. Over the far ridge, dark specks in the white sky.

Rocky shuts his eyes.

ROCKY
(barely audible)
I am tall, fluffy, and green.

And he tears his roots out of the ground.

The SOUND of it -- like the earth clearing its throat -- snow and frozen soil heaving up around his base. It is wrong, it is enormous, it is the one thing trees are never supposed to do. His green dims where the roots come free. He does it anyway.

He drags himself down the slope -- lurching, branches snapping against the drifts, leaving a torn trench behind him in the perfect snow -- as the helicopters clear the far ridge and start down the rows of trees.

EXT. THE SNOW MOUND - CONTINUOUS

Behind the mound: the net, and Mary Louise inside it, and AJ crouched beside it in an agony of not looking at her.

A shadow falls over them both. They look up.

Rocky. Gray already at his base, needles falling, chest heaving. He hooks a branch into the net and pulls. The knots hold. He pulls again -- twigs into twigs, no fingers, no grip, nothing to work with. He keeps pulling.

MARY LOUISE
Rocky -- the judges --

ROCKY
(still pulling)
I know.

The THUD-THUD is over the near rows now. Sweeping closer.

AJ looks from Rocky -- gray to the waist and getting grayer, spending everything, saying nothing -- down to the little fairy in his hands' reach. Something in the small squirrel finally asks itself whose side it is on.

AJ
(blurted)
Why won't you just change him back?
Just -- do the spell backwards!

MARY LOUISE
There's no spell! I just told Rocky
to believe in himself, and he could
do anything!

AJ
...That's it?

MARY LOUISE
Yes.
(gently)
Now, please put me down.

And AJ -- all by himself, with nobody watching and nobody telling him to -- opens the net.

Between his small quick hands and Rocky's last hard pull, the twigs give. Mary Louise shoots up out of the wreck of the net like a spark going home to its fire, wings blazing --

-- just as the helicopters thunder past overhead, low and loud, blotting out everything.

EXT. ROCKY'S CLEARING - MINUTES LATER

Rocky drags himself the last few feet into his hollow and sets his torn roots back into their own ground. Soil and snow settle around his base.

He is gray. Bent again, worse than before. Needles rain off him with every move. The morning light through his gap finds him and there is nothing left in him for it to catch.

He hears the helicopters coming back up the rows.

He straightens what he can straighten. Lifts what he can lift. He stands as tall as he has left, in the middle of his hollow, and looks up.

The helicopters come over the rise --

-- and pass over him without slowing down.

The THUD-THUD fades down the valley. The snow it kicked up settles slowly, softly, all around the little gray tree standing at attention in the quiet.

EXT. THE FAR RIDGE - DAY

Down the valley, the helicopters bank into a wide circle. And hold. Circling one enormous, flawless, deep-green tree.

Bruce Spruce.

The crowd's roar carries all the way up the slope. A RED RIBBON, unspooled from above, settles around Bruce's middle like a sash on a champion. Bruce tips his top and holds out his branches, turning slowly for all of them, soaking it in from every direction at once.

Then, mid-turn, his eyes find the far hollow. The small gray shape in it, still standing at attention.

For exactly one beat, Bruce Spruce holds still.

Then the crowd surges and he is a champion again.

EXT. ROCKY'S CLEARING - DUSK

Mary Louise descends into the hollow, quiet as the snow.

MARY LOUISE

Rocky.

He turns away from her. It is the only unkind thing he does in this entire story, and it isn't even unkind. It is just a tree with nothing left to say folding up the day.

She hovers a long moment. Then she goes.

EXT. ROCKY'S CLEARING - MORNING

Frost. Silence. Rocky, eyes open, looking at nothing.

The moment where he says it comes.

The moment where he says it goes.

He doesn't say it.

And a little more of his color quietly lets go -- one branch fading from gray-green to plain gray, easy as breath misting off in the cold.

EXT. ROCKY'S CLEARING - MORNING - NEXT DAY

The same. Grayer. The bent branch has bent back down.

He doesn't say it.

EXT. ROCKY'S CLEARING - DAY

Mary Louise, hovering in front of him. She has been there a while. The sentence that would fix everything is sitting right there in her mouth, and they both know it.

MARY LOUISE
I could tell you again.

Rocky says nothing.

MARY LOUISE (CONT'D)
(and this costs her)
But it wouldn't be worth anything
the second time.

ROCKY
(very quietly)
Then don't.

She holds there a moment, small and bright and helpless on purpose, which is the hardest way there is to be helpless.

Then she flies away, and her light goes with her, and if a fairy's wings can look heavy, hers do.

EXT. ROCKY'S CLEARING - DUSK

Rocky, gray, alone.

A rustle. He doesn't look. The rustle picks its way down into the hollow, fastidious about the snow --

-- and MRS. PICKLES sits down next to him.

She doesn't say anything. She looks straight ahead, the way he is looking straight ahead. Whatever she came to say, it isn't coming.

After a moment, she takes her little silver mirror -- and sets it face-down on the snow.

They sit there together, the vainest creature in the forest and the saddest, not talking, while it gets dark.

EXT. ROCKY'S CLEARING - MORNING

Gray tree. Gray sky. And then --

AJ (O.S.)
(clearing his throat;
once, twice)
Ahem. AHM.

Rocky's eyes open. AJ stands in the middle of the hollow, paws wrung together, looking exactly like a squirrel who has been rehearsing all night and regrets every choice that brought him here.

And he sings. The old tune -- HIS old tune, the taunt, every child in the audience knows it by now -- but the words have been changed:

AJ (CONT'D)
(squeaky, off-key,
absolutely sincere)
You're tall and green! The finest
tree the forest's ever seen!

Silence.

ROCKY
Don't.

AJ
(singing)
You're tall and green --

ROCKY

AJ. Stop.

AJ does not stop. For the first time in his entire life, AJ is not doing an impression of anybody. He plants his little feet in the snow, and his voice cracks, and he gets the words wrong --

AJ

You're green and tall! The finest --
no, wait --

-- and he starts over, and gets them wrong differently --

AJ (CONT'D)

You're tall and green! The finest
tree --

AJ AND ROCKY

(barely, from Rocky;
mostly to make it stop)
-- the forest's ever seen.

Beat. AJ freezes mid-note. Rocky said it. Sort of. Mostly. AJ decides not to make a thing of it, which for AJ is enormous.

AJ

(quietly now)
Say your one. The real one.

A long moment.

ROCKY

(flat, empty, going
through the motions)
I am tall, fluffy, and green.

Nothing.

AJ

Again.

ROCKY

I am tall, fluffy, and green.

And on the bent branch: one needle stands up.

Rocky stares at it. AJ stares at it. Neither of them breathes.

A rustling on the slope -- and here come the SAPLINGS, picking their way down into the hollow one by one, Pip in the lead, forming up in their ragged dawn row like they've done it a hundred times, because they have.

PIP
All together?

And the little hollow fills up with small voices, none of them in time, all of them wrong in their own way:

SAPLINGS, AJ AND ROCKY
I am tall -- fluffy -- and green --

PIP
-- and FLUFFY!

ROCKY
(and here, at last, the
ghost of a laugh)
Close enough.

EXT. ROCKY'S CLEARING - DAYS - MONTAGE

The green comes back.

Slower this time. Patchier. A branch here, a stripe there. Rocky drinks, stretches, says the words at dawn with a backup choir of five saplings and one squirrel.

He gets to standing. He gets to green -- mostly green. He does not get back to magnificent. What he gets back is himself, a size larger than he started, a size smaller than he dreamed.

It will have to do. He seems, strangely, at peace with that -- or too busy to mourn it. There's a lot of watering to supervise.

EXT. THE HIDDEN FOREST - NIGHT

Still. Warmer than it should be. Then the rain starts --
-- and freezes where it lands.

On branches. On needles. On everything. The forest begins, tick by tick, to turn to glass.

EXT. THE THIN-LIGHT SLOPE - NIGHT

Wind now. The saplings, sheathed in ice, bending -- bending too far. Pip's little trunk creaks like a ship's rope.

Out of the dark, an arm of green: Rocky, braced against the slope, hooking his branches under theirs, taking the weight of the ice on himself.

ROCKY
I've got you. Say your words if
you're scared. Loud as you want.

PIP
(tiny, chattering)
I am tall, fluffy, and green --

ROCKY
That's it. Nobody's falling
tonight.

All around them, out in the dark, the forest CRACKS -- sharp reports, near and far, branches letting go all over the ridge. Each one makes the saplings flinch. Each one, Rocky talks them through.

Then a different sound. Deeper. From down the valley -- a long, groaning SPLIT, like a mast giving way.

Rocky's head comes up.

ROCKY (CONT'D)
(to the saplings)
Hold each other. I'll be back.

EXT. THE FAR RIDGE - NIGHT

Bruce Spruce -- the ribboned champion, the biggest tree in the forest -- is cracking under his own frozen weight. Too broad, too heavy, too much ice on too much glory. A seam has opened low on his flank and it is climbing.

He is not calling for help. He would rather split.

Rocky hauls himself the last of the way down the ridge -- slow, agonizing, half his size and none of his strength -- and sets his trunk against Bruce's trunk, under the bad seam, and pushes. And holds.

Bruce looks down at him. At the little tree he mocked, and schemed against, and beat -- jammed up against him in the dark, taking half a champion's weight on a crooked back.

Bruce Spruce says nothing. All night. There is nothing in him big enough to say it with.

They stand there together, groaning like two ships, while the ice ticks down and the forest cracks around them.

EXT. THE BRAMBLE - NIGHT

The wind finds the tiny house of pebbles and dried leaves. A leaf tears off the roof. Another. The little pencil- line of chimney smoke whips out sideways and vanishes.

Inside, on the workbench: the champion's ornaments, trembling in their rack.

A great green branch reaches down through the bramble -- gently, gently, iced twigs and all -- and gathers the ornaments up into itself, one by one, like a hand collecting eggs.

Rocky. Stretched between the ridge and the bramble to the last inch of himself, sheltering the little glass things in the crook of his branches, his back to the wind.

He holds them till morning.

EXT. THE HIDDEN FOREST - DAWN

Stillness. The storm is gone, and the world it left behind is flattened and glittering -- branches down everywhere, whole trees bowed to the ground, everything sheathed in ice and blazing in the sunrise.

The far ridge: Bruce Spruce stands -- saved -- but his red ribbon hangs on a flank split down one side. The crack stopped where a little tree spent the night holding it shut. He'll live. He won't be lit.

And the thin-light slope: five saplings, upright, blinking in the light. And beside them, where nobody was looking, in the worst light in the forest --

-- one tree standing. Green. Glazed head to foot in ice, every needle cased in glass and catching the sunrise, throwing it back in a thousand pieces.

Rocky, wearing the storm like a crown, too tired to know what he looks like.

Far away, then closer: THUD-THUD-THUD-THUD.

The helicopters clear the ridge, sweep the ruined valley once -- and stop. And circle. And hold.

Over the little gray hollow. Over him.

JUDGE (V.O.)
(over a loudspeaker,
crackling, jubilant)
We found the perfect tree!

Dead silence in the forest below.

Then Pip SCREAMS with joy, and the slope erupts -- animals pouring from everywhere, cheering, tumbling down into the hollow -- and AJ cheers so hard he falls out of a tree into a snowbank and comes up still cheering.

Rocky stands in the middle of it, ice-crowned, stunned, looking up at the circling judges like he cannot make the morning add up.

The crowd parts.

Bruce Spruce has dragged himself up the slope -- split flank, ruined ribbon, enormous and slow. The animals hush. He looks down at Rocky a long moment.

Then Bruce Spruce tips his top. All the way. Lower than he has ever tipped it for anyone.

BRUCE SPRUCE
(to the whole forest; it
costs him plenty)
The net was mine. The trap was my
idea. This tree lost his green
getting the fairy out of it -- the
morning of the judging. He knew
what it would cost. He went anyway.
(beat)
They found the right tree.

Murmurs. Nobody punishes him. Nobody has to. Mrs. Pickles looks at Bruce over the top of her mirror, and for once says nothing at all, which from Mrs. Pickles is a standing ovation.

High above them all, unnoticed, a tiny light loops one slow, glad circle over the hollow -- and zips away.

FADE OUT.

END OF ACT TWO

ACT THREE

EXT. ROCKY'S CLEARING - DAY

The celebration has gone quiet.

Because a TRUCK has come. It sits at the forest's edge where no truck has ever been, engine ticking, breath of the men rising -- and off the back of it, wrapped in canvas, comes the long shape of a SAW.

The animals stand in a wide, silent ring around the hollow. Rocky looks at the saw for a long time.

ROCKY
(quietly, to the Old Oak)
The story never says this part out loud.

OLD OAK
No.
(beat)
It says "carried out of the forest." This is how a tree is carried.

ROCKY
Does it hurt?

OLD OAK
I don't know. No tree has ever come back to complain about it.
(gently, for him alone)
They don't come back, Rocky, because they go ON. Every one of them. You know where.

Rocky looks past the truck, past the ridge, at the far white sky.

ROCKY
(a whisper)
The top of the world.

He is frightened. Anyone could see it. Every needle of him wants his own thin soil.

ROCKY (CONT'D)
(to the men, to the forest, to himself)
Yes.

EXT. ROCKY'S CLEARING - LATER

The goodbyes.

The saplings all talk at once, and Pip doesn't talk at all, just presses his little top against Rocky's trunk and stays there until his brothers pull him off.

The Old Oaks grumble that it is too cold for all this standing around, and their voices fail on every third word, and they do not go inside.

Mrs. Pickles is being extremely brave. She has prepared remarks. She gets four words into them.

MRS. PICKLES

Well. Grandest tree for --

And that's as far as the remarks go. She waves her mirror at him -- go on, GO -- and turns away so he won't see her face, and her tail knocks snow off three bushes.

Mary Louise comes last. She carries -- with four other fairies' worth of effort -- a little woven basket. Inside, nested in moss: the champion's ornaments. The ones he sheltered all night.

MARY LOUISE

These go where you're going.

(beat)

Carry them for me?

Rocky takes the basket into his branches like it is made of soap bubbles.

ROCKY

Will you be there?

MARY LOUISE

(a wink)

Every needle.

EXT. ROCKY'S CLEARING - MOMENTS LATER

The men take their positions at his base. The forest holds its breath -- all of it, every animal, every tree, one held breath along the whole ridge.

Rocky shuts his eyes.

We stay on his face. Only his face.

OLD OAK (V.O.)

(the story voice, warm and worn)

Carried out. Carried up. Lit for all the world to see --

The SOUND of the saw starts, far down at the bottom of the frame of the world --

OLD OAK (V.O.)
-- and remembered, evermore --

ROCKY
(eyes shut; steady)
-- at the top of the world.

A tremble runs up through him, once, from root to star- point
--

-- and the sky behind his top begins, very slowly, to move.

The forest bows. All of it, along the whole ridge, every tree bending as one -- the way the forest bowed in the Old Oak's story, all those pages ago -- while the little tree from the thin light is carried out on the shoulders of the wind and the men.

EXT. THE HIGHWAY - DAY

A FLATBED TRUCK rolls south on a two-lane road, and on it, cradled and bound in soft netting, rides ROCKY -- horizontal, watching his whole known world slide away upside down and backward.

The last trees of the hidden forest slip past. Then fields. Then fences. Then more world than he ever guessed there was.

A rustle in the netting beside his top -- and AJ's head pops out of Rocky's branches, cheeks stuffed with nuts.

ROCKY
AJ?!

AJ
(around the nuts)
I packed.

ROCKY
You can't come to New York!

AJ
(settling in, done
discussing it)
You can't go alone.

Rocky opens his mouth to argue. Finds nothing in stock. Somewhere under the netting, his branches make room.

From lower down the load, a voice of cold dignity:

MRS. PICKLES (O.S.)
If anyone is interested, I was
INSPECTING my reflection in that
hubcap, the vehicle DEPARTED, and I
am owed an apology by everyone
involved.

AJ leans over the side. Mrs. Pickles is wedged between two
coils of rope, mirror out, repairing her windblown hair at
forty miles an hour.

AJ
You could've jumped off at the
crossroads.

MRS. PICKLES
(combing)
And LEAVE Rocky? Certainly not.
(catching herself)
...Leave Rocky ALONE with you, I
mean. Obviously.

She goes back to her hair. AJ grins at Rocky. Rocky grins at
the sky.

EXT. THE HIGHWAY - VARIOUS - DAY AND NIGHT

America, going by:

-- Grain silos with their tops in the clouds. Rocky cranes to
see. He thought only trees got that tall.

-- A small town, strung with lights, where kids on an
overpass hold a bedsheet banner: WE LOVE YOU ROCKY. He does
not know how they know his name. He waves a branch anyway,
and the overpass goes crazy.

-- Rain on the netting. AJ asleep in the deep of the
branches. Mrs. Pickles, sound asleep, still holding the
mirror up.

-- A second flatbed, riding behind theirs. On it, bound and
enormous: BRUCE SPRUCE. Invited -- as the forest's second-
finest -- to stand at the plaza. He is handling it
gracefully.

BRUCE SPRUCE
(calling forward,
unprompted, again)
They needed a big tree for the
PLAZA. Standing by the RINK. Where
the CROWDS are. It is a very
important assignment!

AJ
(not looking up)
Nobody asked, Bruce.

BRUCE SPRUCE
(beat)
It is a VERY important assignment.

EXT. TRUCK STOP - NIGHT - 2 A.M.

A diner lot off the interstate, lit orange. The trucks tick and cool. Snow drifts through the light poles.

TRUCKERS -- warm shapes, faces in shadow, breath in the cold --
- gather loosely around the flatbed with paper cups of
coffee, looking up at the bound tree the way people look at
something on its way to mattering.

One raises his cup an inch. The others follow. Nobody says
anything. They drink to him and go inside.

AJ, tucked in the branches, watches them go.

AJ
(softly)
They toasted you.

ROCKY
(looking up; the sky is
orange, starless,
strange)
AJ... how far is home?

AJ
(a beat; no rhyme for this
one)
Far.

EXT. NEW YORK CITY - DAY

And then the world stands up.

Towers. Canyons of glass. Windows like stars stood on end --
the Old Oak's story, real, and bigger than the telling, and
louder, and everywhere. Yellow rivers of taxis. Steam from
the street grates like the whole city is breathing.

The flatbed threads through it all, tiny now. On it, Rocky
rides with his mouth open. For the first time since the
hollow, he is the smallest thing anywhere he looks -- and it
is strangely like coming home to something.

MRS. PICKLES
(mirror forgotten, face to
the sky)
Oh my.

AJ
(also gaping)
It's like the story.

ROCKY
No.
(beat)
It's bigger.

EXT. ROCKEFELLER CENTER - DAY

The plaza. Golden statue, flags of every color snapping, the rink white and waiting. A CRANE stands over an empty place at the center of everything -- a Rocky-shaped hole in the middle of the world.

Cables. Rigging. GLOVED HANDS -- warm, faceless, efficient -- securing the straps.

And the lift:

Rocky rises off the flatbed and swings out over Fifth Avenue -- a small tree from a hidden forest, turning slowly on a cable, sixty feet over the sidewalks of New York, the crowds below pointing up, the towers wheeling around him, the whole world underneath.

His eyes are shut tight.

ROCKY
(a chant under his breath)
Tall, fluffy, green, tall, fluffy,
green, TALL, FLUFFY --

He is set down -- guided into the base -- braced, bolted, steadied.

Planted. In the exact center of the greatest city on earth.

EXT. ROCKEFELLER CENTER - LATER

The netting comes off.

It should be a great moment. It is not.

After days bound in the dark and cold, Rocky's branches hang crushed along one whole side.

His color, patchy since the storm, has gone dull road-gray. He is bent. He is small -- the towers see to that -- smaller than he has ever looked anywhere, ever.

His branches try to lift. Some of them make it.

The gloved hands slow. Stop. The warm faceless shapes of the CREW stand back and look at him, and the looking stretches on too long.

CREW VOICE (O.S.)
(low; not unkind, which is
the worst part)
...Maybe we should've taken the big
one.

Nobody answers. Which is an answer.

The crew drifts off. The lights of the plaza shut down section by section -- clunk, clunk, clunk -- and the scaffolding stands empty, and the little tree is left bent in the dark in the middle of everything.

EXT. ROCKEFELLER CENTER - NIGHT

Late. Empty. The rink a dark mirror. Steam rising somewhere. The city rumbling to itself, far away on every side.

Rocky, alone.

No forest. No thin soil that knows him. No saplings, no oaks. AJ and Mrs. Pickles -- asleep somewhere down in the rigging, out of earshot. No wee voice coming. He knows by now that it isn't coming. It isn't supposed to.

He looks up. Between the towers, a strip of night sky. No stars. City glow. Nothing up there knows him either.

ROCKY
(barely)
I am tall --

It dies in his throat.

He tries again.

ROCKY (CONT'D)
I am --

Nothing. The words have no floor under them. He stands in the dark, bent, dull, finished --

-- and then, off the rink's dark mirror, something catches his eye: the empty plaza reflected. The scaffolding. The thousand folding chairs. The barriers, row on row, ready for a crowd.

Ready for thousands. Tomorrow. In the cold.

Children on shoulders. Grandmothers in scarves. Kids on overpasses who somehow knew his name. A whole city -- the whole world, the Old Oak said -- coming here, to see one thing.

Coming to see something beautiful.

And he is what they are going to get.

Rocky looks at the empty chairs a long, long moment.

Then he straightens what he can straighten -- and this time it is not for the judges, and it is not for Bruce, and it is not even for the dream.

ROCKY (CONT'D)
(flat; quiet; to no one;
for everyone)
I am tall, fluffy, and green.

Beat.

ROCKY (CONT'D)
I am tall, fluffy, and green.

And a branch lifts.

Not a burst. Not a miracle with trumpets. One crushed branch, waking, rising slowly into place. Then, a long moment later, another. Then two more.

Over one full minute, in a dead-empty plaza, in the middle of the sleeping city -- branch by branch, side by crushed side, needle by needle flooding back to deep glossy green -- the little tree OPENS.

And as he opens, the snow begins. Fat flakes, the size of marshmallows, drifting down between the towers, settling on his rising branches -- the forest's own snow, come all this way, like it knew.

No one sees any of it happen.

That was always the point.

EXT. ROCKEFELLER CENTER - NIGHT - THE LIGHTING

And now: everyone.

The plaza PACKED, shoulder to shoulder, breath rising from thousands -- a warm, faceless, joyful sea, scarves and shoulders and lifted children, every face a small warm blur turned up toward the center.

Rocky -- full, green, magnificent at last, and magnificent in the only way that was ever really going to work: his own crooked top, his own funny angles, grown clean through with glory -- stands dressed in RED ORNAMENTS and a mile of unlit lights.

High in his branches, where only we can see: a tiny light zips from twig to twig. MARY LOUISE, hanging her champion's ornaments with her own hands -- the globes of frozen dew, and last of all the snowflake star, the ones he sheltered from the storm. Only she and Rocky and we will ever know what they went through to be here.

MARY LOUISE
(privately, to him,
setting the last one)
Made for the champion.
(a wink)
I always finish my work.

Below, at the rink's edge, boosted onto a barrier for the view: AJ, vibrating. Beside him, Mrs. Pickles has her mirror up, of course she does, combing, admiring, narrating her own hair --

-- and in the corner of the little silver mirror, over her own shoulder, hangs a tree full of unlit promise.

She stops combing.

She turns around. The mirror sinks, forgotten, all by itself.

MRS. PICKLES
(softly; to nobody; an old
question, finally
answered)
THAT'S what makes you think.

At the back of the plaza, over by the rink he guards, towering above the crowd: BRUCE SPRUCE, second-finest tree in the forest, on very important assignment. He is not performing anything. He is just looking up at Rocky, quiet as a tree.

A hush rolls over the plaza. This is it.

Somewhere a switch --

-- and ROCKY LIGHTS.

Bottom to top, a rising tide of gold and green and red and blue, tens of thousands of lights taking fire through his branches, the snowflake star catching all of it at once -- and the CROWD ROAR goes up like the whole city took one breath and let it go, and the light of the little tree from the thin soil falls on every upturned face for a block in every direction.

Hold on it. The full picture. The dream, out loud.

AJ is crying and would deny it. Mrs. Pickles is not even pretending. Bruce tips his top -- small, private, nobody watching. The lights dance on the dark rink like a second tree lying in the ice.

And around Rocky's shoulders, in a spiral, trailing sparks that are lost among the bulbs, flies Mary Louise -- one last, slow, glad circle, her wings sparkling like the lights on his branches.

MARY LOUISE

Always remember: if you believe
without a doubt and don't give up --
you can do anything your heart
desires!

ROCKY

(shining; there is only
one thing left to ask)
Will I see you again?

MARY LOUISE

(drifting up, backward,
into the snow; a wink)
See you at the North Pole -- with
all the Rockefeller Christmas Trees
from years gone by!

And she is gone, the way she is always gone, before anyone is ready.

Rocky looks out over the sea of faces -- all the world, glad, exactly like the story said.

He tips his top -- carefully, carefully, careful not to drop his star --

-- and raises one branch, and waves.

The crowd waves back. All of it. Thousands of mittens in the falling snow.

EXT. A GREEN HILLSIDE - DAY (SPRING)

Birdsong. Sawdust. Hammers, cheerful and unhurried.

On a green hillside stands the honest yellow frame of a SMALL HOUSE, half-built, smelling of fresh-cut spruce. Warm, faceless people carry boards and call to each other. The boards are a wood we know.

OLD OAK (V.O.)
(the story voice)
And when the lights came down, the
chosen tree gave one more gift --
the way chosen trees always do.

EVENING. The house finished. A FAMILY -- warm shapes, faces soft in the dusk -- stands in the doorway of their new home. The porch light comes on.

OLD OAK (V.O.)
His wood became a home. Which, if
you ask an old tree, is the only
thing worth being after you've been
beautiful.

EXT. THE OAKS' RISE - NIGHT (NEXT WINTER)

Snow falling. New saplings -- Pip among them, taller now, greener now -- gathered beneath the Old Oak.

OLD OAK
...And that is the story of the
little tree from the thin light.

PIP
Tell the ending. Tell where he is
NOW.

OLD OAK
I told it last year.

PIP
TELL IT.

The Old Oak grumbles. Creaks. Settles. And the snow between his branches begins to glow --

EXT. THE NORTH POLE - NIGHT (STORYBOOK)

The top of the world. Northern lights rippling like curtains over endless white.

And on the great hill: THE TREES. Rows and rows and rows of them, every Rockefeller tree from every year gone by, every one still dressed in its own year's lights, still shining -- a forest made entirely of remembered Christmases.

The rows stir. Shift. The great old trees lean apart, opening a space in the very heart of the hill -- a space just the right size for a small spruce with a slightly crooked top.

They made room.

And there he stands among them, lit and laughing, home at the top of the world: ROCKY. His star -- the snowflake star, the champion's star -- burning at his crooked tip like it grew there.

Overhead, in perfect formation, a team of REINDEER sweeps across the northern lights -- clearing every single snowdrift on the hill below with room to spare. The last one in line clips nothing at all.

YOUNG REINDEER
(calling down, joyous)
I PACED MYSELF!

And over it all, the old voice, warm as a lit window:

OLD OAK (V.O.)
It was Rocky's happiest day ever.
(beat; creakier; quieter)
It still is.

The snow falls. The lights shine. The little tree stands with all the trees who ever were, at the top of the world, forever.

CUT TO BLACK.

THE END